

Giving the Benefit of the Doubt

DURATION	35–40 min · Week 3
OBJECTIVE	Students practice charitable interpretation as a deliberate cognitive habit.
CASEL FOCUS	Social Awareness: charitable interpretation · Responsible Decision-Making
VOCABULARY	interpretation, charitable, doubt, assume, generous, default
MATERIALS	Journals · WS9 Pause Practice · Anchor chart · Scenario cards

OPENING REVIEW

2 Minutes

“We extend grace and mercy in actions. Today: extending grace in our minds — before any action. The pause between something happening and how you read it is where grace lives.”

1

Define Charitable Interpretation

2–10 MIN

Choosing the kinder read of someone's behavior when you don't know all the facts. Not naive. A deliberate choice when there are multiple possible explanations.

2

The Pause Practice (WS9)

10–18 MIN

Four steps: (1) NOTICE the assumption forming. (2) PAUSE before acting. (3) ASK what other explanations might fit. (4) CHOOSE the most charitable one consistent with what you know.

3

Scenario Practice

18–28 MIN

Apply the four-step pause practice. Note: charitable interpretation does not apply to ongoing harmful patterns.

4

Personal Reflection

28–35 MIN

Journal: When have I assumed the worst about someone — and been wrong? What would charitable interpretation have looked like?

IN-LESSON SCAN

During the journal: a student who genuinely cannot recall a single instance of being wrong about someone may be in an environment where assuming the worst has been protective. This is data about their context.

GRADE 3

GRADES 4 — 5